Automatic Child Support Intermediation in France

Data and Empirical Strategy

Public Economics – Research Proposal

ENSAE – Institut Polytechnique de Paris

October 2026

Data: Source, Coverage, and Sample

Dimension	Proposed data and sample
Data source	ALLSTAT-FR6, administrative records on beneficiaries of the French Family Allowance Funds (CAF), produced by CNAF and available for research through CASD authorization.
Geographical coverage	France; main analysis restricted to metropolitan France to ensure consistent geographical coverage.
Study period	2017–2025, covering several years before and after the 2022–2023 IFPA reform.
Unit of observation	CAF beneficiary case $\times$ month, with longitudinal tracking of households where identifiers permit.
Target population	Single-parent beneficiary households with dependent children, focusing on families with identifiable child support arrangements.
Sample construction	Identify single-parent households, construct monthly trajectories, and distinguish recorded child support obligations from missing information.
Data access	ALLSTAT-FR6 is documented in the CASD catalogue;

Data: Sample Construction and Observation Unit

1. **Identify the study population.** Select single-parent CAF households with dependent children using `SITFAM` (family status), `PRESCONJ` (partner presence) and `NBENLEFA` (dependent children).
2. **Construct longitudinal observations.** Use reference dates and anonymised identifiers (`DTREFFRE`, `IDANORES`) to assess whether households can be followed across periods. Check changes in beneficiary status and CAF transfers.
3. **Identify child support arrangements.** Use `TPA` (child support indicator), `MTPADU` (amount due) and `MTALIMFO` (amount received by the household).
4. **Characterise family transitions.** Use `NBMSIFAM` (months since the last change in family status) to approximate recent changes, without interpreting them automatically as separations.
5. **Assess treatment identification.** Investigate `NATJUG` (nature of the judicial decision concerning a defaulting child support debtor) and the availability of enforceable-order dates before defining reform-exposure cohorts.

Proposed observation unit

One CAF beneficiary case at each available reference date, with child support information, family characteristics, social benefits and reported resources.

Data: Measuring Child Support

Variable	Dictionary description	Potential use
MTPADU	Amount of child support due	Measure of recorded child support obligations.
MTALIMFO	Child support received by the household	Candidate outcome: child support receipts.
MTALIMME	Child support received by the woman	Gender-specific measure of receipts.
MTALIMVE	Child support paid by the household	Potential measure of outgoing child support.
MTPALIFT	Quarterly child support received by the household	Alternative measure of receipts over a quarterly reference period.
TPA	Child support indicator	Identification of households with recorded child support information.
NBDEBPEN	Number of debtors associated with ASF	Potential information on child support debtors in the ASF system.

Measurement issue

Recorded amounts may reflect declared resources rather than verified payments. Amounts due and received cannot yet be used to calculate an arrears rate.

Data: Outcomes and Control Variables

Category	ALLSTAT variables	Measurement and empirical role
Primary outcome	MTALIMFO, MTPALIFT	Child support received by the household. Main outcome for assessing changes in recorded receipts following the reform.
Social transfers	ASFVERS, ASFCOMPL	Family Support Allowance (ASF) and complementary ASF amounts payable. Potential adjustment when child support receipts change.
Other benefits	RSAVERS; Prime d'activité (amount variable to confirm)	Changes in means-tested benefits, potentially affected by child support and household resources.
Household resources	MTRNIFOY	Household net taxable income. Proxy for economic resources, not a direct measure of disposable income.
Demographics	SEXE, DTNAIRES, NBENLEFA	Sex and age of the beneficiary; number of dependent children.
Family composition	SITFAM, PRESCONJ, NBMSIFAM	Family status, partner presence and months since the last family-status change.
Geography	NUMCOMDO	Municipality identifier for geographical heterogeneity and potential area controls.

Measurement and identification

ASF was revalued in November 2022, independently of the IFPA rollout. Benefit amounts and taxable income are not equivalent to disposable income. Controls must be measured before treatment.

Data: Policy Exposure and Measurement Challenges

Staggered implementation of automatic intermediation

March 2022: automatic financial intermediation for newly fixed child support in judicial divorce proceedings.
January 2023: extension to other enforceable child support orders.

Information required	Candidate ALLSTAT information	Implications for identification
Date of child support order	No confirmed variable identifying the date of the enforceable order	First recorded pension cannot be interpreted as a newly established obligation.
Type of enforceable title	`NATJUG`: nature of a judicial decision concerning a defaulting debtor	Cannot yet distinguish judicial divorces from other eligible procedures.
IFPA participation	No direct participation indicator identified in the reviewed dictionary	Eligibility and actual treatment cannot be distinguished.
Child support payments	`MTPADU`, `MTALIMFO`, `MTPALIFT`	Amounts due and received may not reflect verified monthly payments.

Key identification constraint

The reform's staggered rollout provides potential policy variation, but causal identification requires reliable information on order dates and legal categories.

Methodology: Source of Identification

Methodology: Equation and Estimand

Methodology: Assumptions, Threats, and Feasibility

References and Data Documentation

- **CASD:** ALLSTAT-FR6, *Fichier statistique des allocataires des CAF – données définitives*. `https://www.casd.eu/source/fichier-statistique-des-allocataires-des-caf-donnees-definitives/`
- **CNAF (2024):** *Évaluation du dispositif d'intermédiation financière des pensions alimentaires en phase de généralisation*, Dossier d'étude no. 233.
- **CNAF / DREES (2025):** statistical analysis of the November 2022 ASF revaluation (ALLSTAT-FR6).
- **Rubolino, E.:** *Outlining Data and Methodology*, Public Economics, ENSAE–IP Paris (course slides).

Status

Proposed research design based on public data documentation; no access to individual ALLSTAT records or validated causal sample is claimed.